01_INITIAL SUBMISSION BY RESEARCHER

These are the required documents and forms to be submitted by the researcher/proponent:

1. USC REC F-26 - Document Receipt Form *(in word format)*
2. Cover Letter *(in PDF format)*
3. USC REC F-27 - Research Protocol Application Form *(in word format)*
4. USC REC F-28 - Data Privacy Consent Form *(in PDF format)*
5. USC REC F-35 - Protocol Review Assessment Form *(in word format)*
6. USC REC F-36 - Informed Consent Form Assessment Checklist *(in word format)*
7. USC REC F-30 - Detailed Budget Sheet *(in PDF format)*
8. Research proposal/manuscript *(in PDF format)*, including the following as appendices:
    a. Appendix A - Informed Consent Form/Assent Form *(if applicable)*;
    b. Appendix B - Research Instrument *(if applicable)*;
    c. Appendix C – screenshot of the online form *(if applicable)*;
    d. Appendix D - Other supporting documents (transmittal letter; letter of request to use the research instrument, approval sheet, etc. *(if applicable)*
    e. Appendix E - CVs of researcher(s); and
    f. Appendix F - CV of adviser *(if applicable)*.

NOTE: USC REC F-29 - Capsule Proposal is no longer used.

If complete, the REC staff will assign a unique protocol code to the application:

YEAR-Sequence Number-<Family name of the researcher>

e.g. 2026-001-Abregana

For multiple researchers:

YEAR-Sequence Number-<Family name of the first researcher> et al

e.g. 2026-001-Abregana et al

The REC staff will then forward the application to the Panel Chair for determination of the type of review. If the Panel Chair has COI, the Panel Vice-Chair will determine the type of review.

02_DETERMINE TYPE OF REVIEW BY PANEL CHAIR

The Panel Chair will determine the type of review whether the application is for Full Review, Expedited Review or Exempted from Review by filling out **USC REC F-31 - Form on Determining the Type of Review**.

If the application is exempted from review, the Panel Chair will fill out the following:

- **USC REC F-31 - Form on Determining the Type of Review**
- **USC REC F-41 - Checklist for Exemption from Review**

A billing statement will be given to the researcher to settle the review fee
USC REC F-42 - Certification of Exemption from Review will be sent to the researcher/proponent once the researcher has settled the fee

NOTE: Sir Gran, I don't know how will you do this but there are times that the Panel Chair will have a few recommendations to be done by the researcher. The researcher will then resubmit the revised research proposal based on the recommendations of the Panel Chair. Please note that the version number of the protocol will still be version 1. Once the researcher has complied with the recommendations by the Panel Chair, **USC REC F-42 - Certification of Exemption from Review** will be
Issued.

If the protocol is for Full or Expedited Review, the Panel Chair will assign 2 reviewers (**USC REC F-31**): 1 **scientist** to review the scientific validity of the study and 1 **non-scientist** to review the Informed Consent/Assent Form(s)

Sample communication to reviewers assigned:

> With the secretariat's endorsement of this protocol, I designate **Angie Ceniza-Canillo, PhD** as the scientist in-charge of evaluating the PRAF and **Beethoven Arellano, Jr.** as the nonscientist in-charge of evaluating the ICF with the usual considerations as follows:
>
> 1. This designation **shall be deemed accepted after 72 hours** absent any conflict of interest declaration or other related objections from any of us. Upon acceptance, the primary reviewers are expected to provide their reviews within the indicated deadline.
> 2. May our primary reviewers use this email thread for the purpose of submitting the protocol review and/or correspondence relating to the subject protocol expeditiously. *Please "Reply ALL" when sending your review.*
>
> This protocol is for Expedited Review . While the proposed age range of 25–65 years includes individuals aged 60 and above, classified under PHREB/NEGRIHP as a vulnerable population by age, the participants are engaged strictly in their professional capacity to provide insights on facility gaps, service delivery, workflows, and architectural

requirements. The study does not investigate aging, geriatric care, age-related cognition, or age-specific clinical experience, nor does it compare perspectives across age cohorts; thus, including participants aged 60 and above is not analytically necessary. Accordingly, the methodology should be revised to cap the upper age limit at 59 years, with a brief justification that the study focuses on institutional, professional, and spatial considerations rather than age-related or geriatric perspectives.

We hope to receive your review **on or before 23 January 2026.**

The reviewer has the right not to accept to review the protocol for a reason within the 72 hours. The Panel Chair will then re-designate it to other reviewers

03_REVIEW BY REVIEWERS

The **scientist** will use **USC REC F-35 - Protocol Review Assessment Form**
The **non-scientist** will use **USC REC F-36 - Informed Consent Form Assessment Checklist**

- They are given 10 working days
- There should be NO BLANKS (comments and recommendations should be filled-out)
- Recommendations that requires revision by the researcher should be highlighted by yellow
- There should be **recommended action**.
- **Justification** should be filled out
- Name, signature and date should be filled out by the reviewers

04_REVIEW BY PANEL CHAIR

Once the reviewers will send their review (F-35 and 36), the Panel Chair will review the consolidated review (**USC REC F-37 - Summary of Reviewers Comments**). The form will be signed by the REC staff and the Panel Secretary (if Full Review). Endorsed and signed by the Panel Chair.

The Panel Chair can edit the comments and recommendations including the Recommended Action and Justification.

05_REVIEW RESULT SENT TO RESEARCHER

If the protocol is not approved
a decision letter (USC REC F-39 - Notification of REC Decision) will be sent to the researcher. Please note that the letter contains 3 options: *For Protocols that are Approved; For Protocols that need Modifications (Major/Minor); For Protocols that are Disapproved*

Must have the name and signature of the Panel Chair including the date. If the Panel Chair has COI, it should be the name of the Panel Vice-Chair. If both are COI, the name of the REC Chair.

The researcher will receive the following:

1. **USC REC F-39 - Notification of REC Decision**
2. **USC REC F-37 - Summary of Reviewers Comments**

If the protocol is APPROVED by both reviewers, the researcher will receive **USC REC F-40 - Certification of Approval. The researcher will have to submit to REC the signed F-40. F-39 will be used by the REC staff but will not be sent to the researcher.**

06_REVISED RESEARCH PROPOSAL AND FORM 38

The researcher will then revise their research proposal based on the recommendations from REC **(version 2-<date of revision>)**. The revisions should be highlighted in the research proposal. They will also fill out **USC REC F-38 - Summary of Actions Taken. It must be signed by the researcher/s and adviser**

NOTE: The Primary Reviewer should NOT be seen by the researcher/s and adviser

07_REVIEW RESULT SENT TO RESEARCHER

The assigned reviewers will review the revised research proposal and will fill out **USC REC F-38 - Summary of Actions Taken** under **"Panel/ Reviewers' Remarks"**

The reviewer is required to fill out the **RECOMMENDED ACTION & JUSTIFICATION FOR RECOMMENDATION.** They are also required to put their name, signature and date.

If there are still recommendations not addressed by the researcher, the reviewer must highlight their new recommendation under **"Panel/ Reviewers' Remarks"**

If it is still NOT APPROVED, the researcher will receive the following:

1. **USC REC F-39 - Notification of REC Decision**
2. **USC REC F-38 - Summary of Actions Taken (review result) WITHOUT the name, signature of the reviewer**

They are required to resubmit their **revised research proposal (version 3-<date of revision>, etc.) and Form-38 (with the remaining recommendations not addressed.**

If the **protocol is APPROVED**, the researcher will receive **USC REC F-40 - Certification of Approval. The researcher will have to submit to REC the signed F-40.**
F-39 and F-38 will be used by the REC staff but will not be sent to the researcher.